

The Connected Star

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FEATURES

A couple of Jekyll updates

Eddie Smith (*Practically Efficient*)

Since moving to Jekyll last year, I've done relatively little to tweak the inner workings of this site. After all, one of the most appealing things about having a static site is that it doesn't need to have a lot of moving parts. It just works.

But today I finally got around to a couple of housekeeping items that have been on my list: image captions and MathJax.

Image captions

For image captions, I settled on a beautifully simple solution posted by Andrew Wei on Stack Overflow :

```
 *image_caption*
```

This takes advantage of the fact that you can create CSS for combinations of HTML elements. In this case, I can use

```
img + em { display: block; text-align: center;}
```

to target the `*image_caption*` text only and center it under images, which are also centered on this site by default. It works perfectly, and this isn't even Jekyll-specific. Anyone publishing in Markdown could do this.

Agreed.

Jekyll + MathJax

Adding MathJax took a little more time, but not much. It was worth it just to remind me of the brilliance of Jekyll's architecture. Even though the Jekyll site mentions MathJax , it doesn't say enough to be of immediate use. It basically points to a blog post that entails switching from the default kramdown Markdown converter to redcarpet . Given that I'm happy with kramdown and not in the mood to backtest a bunch of blog posts with a different converter, I wanted to stick with kramdown .

A series of subsequent web searches lead me to a Github issue thread for a Jekyll theme that I'm not even using, but I found a really efficient implementation of MathJax there by user "mmistakes," who suggested adding a `mathjax` variable in each page's YAML front matter that could be set to `true` on a post by post basis.

The elegance of this solution is that the MathJax script will only be written into the HTML of posts that actually have MathJax in them. This seemed super appealing to me because it meant that I didn't have to worry about MathJax being triggered by some accidental combination of characters in an old blog post.

I ended up adding

```
{% if page.mathjax %}
{% endif %}
```

to my `head.html` file, which contains Ruby instructions for building the contents of each page's element. For any page where the YAML front matter has `mathjax: true` , the MathJax script will be included. I decided to always include it in the site's `index.html` file, which shows recent posts. And going forward, I can simply include it in the YAML front matter of any individual post. For example, this post's front matter is:

```
— layout: post title: A couple of Jekyll updates mathjax: true
—
```

I just finished up a project where I worked with MathJax a lot, and I continue to be impressed at how many LaTeX commands it handles. MathJax even has a special `enclose` library that handles special actuarial notation that eludes so many people. For example,

```
$$\require{enclose} {}_{-17|}\ddot{a}_{-x:\enclose{actuarial}}{n}}^{{(4)}}$$
```

turns into:

```
\[\require{enclose} {}_{-17|}\ddot{a}_{-x:\enclose{actuarial}}{n}}^{{(4)}}\]
```

Fun.

EFF to Wisconsin Legislature: VPN Bans Are Still a Terrible Idea

Rindala Alajaji · EFF Deeplinks

Update, February 25, 2026: In response to widespread push-back, Wisconsin lawmakers have removed the provision banning VPN services from S. B. 130 / A. B. 105. The bill now awaits Governor Tony Evers' signature. While the removal of the VPN provision is a positive step, EFF continues to oppose the bill. Advocates and residents across Wisconsin are urged to maintain pressure and encourage Governor Evers to veto the bill.

Wisconsin's S. B. 130 / A. B. 105 is a spectacularly bad idea.

It's an age-verification bill that effectively bans VPN access to certain websites for Wisconsinites and censors lawful speech. We wrote about it last November in our blog "Lawmakers Want to Ban VPNs—And They Have No Idea What They're Doing," but since then, the bill has passed the State Assembly and is scheduled for a vote in the State Senate tomorrow.

In light of this, EFF sent a letter to the entire Wisconsin Legislature urging lawmakers to reject this dangerous bill.

You can read the full letter here .

The short version? This bill both requires invasive age verification for websites that host content lawmakers might deem "sexual" and requires that those sites block any user that connects via a Virtual Private Network (VPN). VPNs are a basic cybersecurity tool used by businesses, universities, journalists, veterans, abuse survivors, and ordinary people who simply don't want to broadcast their location to every website they visit.

As we lay out in the letter, Wisconsin's mandate is technically unworkable. Websites cannot reliably determine whether a VPN user is in Wisconsin, a different state, or a different country. So, to avoid liability, websites are faced with an unfortunate choice: either resort to over-blocking IP addresses commonly associated with commercial VPNs, block all Wisconsin users' access, or mandate nationwide restrictions just to avoid liability.

The bill also creates a privacy nightmare. It pushes websites to collect sensitive personal data (e.g. government IDs, financial information, biometric identifiers) just to access lawful speech. At the same time, it broadens the definition of material deemed "harmful to minors" far beyond the narrow categories courts have historically allowed states to regulate. The definition goes far beyond the narrow categories historically recognized by courts (namely, explicit adult sexual materials) and instead sweeps in material that merely describes sex or depicts human anatomy. This approach invites over-censorship, chills lawful speech, and exposes websites to vague and unpredictable enforcement. That combination—mass data collection plus vague, expansive speech restrictions—is a recipe for over-censorship, data breaches, and constitutional overreach.

If you live in Wisconsin, now is the time for you to contact your State Senator and urge them to vote NO on S. B. 130 / A. B. 105 . Tell them protecting young people online should not mean undermining cybersecurity, chilling lawful speech, and forcing residents to hand over their IDs just to browse the internet.

As we said last time : Our privacy matters. VPNs matter. And politicians who can't tell the difference between a security tool and a "loophole" shouldn't be writing laws about the internet.

Tales From the Beat Episode 130: Competitive Paranoia

Ed Garsten, TTAC Creator · *The Truth About Cars*

There's of course, a lot of great journalism out there, but if you look at your newsfeed, there's a lot of crap too.

If you're old enough, like I am, you remember when, instead of making stuff up, we simply, um, borrowed, from places like the New York Times and Washington Post. At least that's what we did quite often at CNN back in the day. So in episode 130 of Tales From the Beat, I turn the wayback machine to 1986 when a NY Times story caught the attention of a big boss at CNN, and I was ordered to match it and ask a question that received an honest answer that I couldn't include in my piece. The ep includes that story, and a much younger me, host Ed Garsten.

TTAC Creator Ed Garsten hosts "Tales from the Beat," a podcast about the automotive and media worlds. A veteran reporter and public relations operative, Garsten worked for CNN, The Associated Press, The Detroit News, Chrysler's PR department and Franco Public Relations. He is currently a senior contributor for Forbes.

The TTAC Creators Series tells stories and amplifies creators from all corners of the car world, including culture, dealerships, collections, modified builds and more.

A transcript, cleaned up via AI and edited by a staffer, is below.

Ed. note – this article ran previously and has been brought forward for those who missed it the first time.

[Image: YouTube Screenshot]

Become a TTAC insider. Get the latest news, features, TTAC takes, and everything else that gets to the truth about cars first by subscribing to our newsletter.

Transcript:

Competitive paranoia and how it's escalated.

Hi everyone, I'm Ed Garsten, and welcome to episode 130 of Tales from the Beat, where we look at news and PR from both sides of the scrimmage line.

Have you checked your news feed lately? Ever wonder where some of that garbage comes from? I've got a few examples here. Psychology says if you bring up these nine topics in conversation, you have below-average social skills. Things like graphic health details. So, what—saying "I feel like crap today" is wrong now?

Here's another one: "Rock icon, 66, calls out artists acting 25 at 65." What? I don't think that's cool for the fans. It just says, "Okay."

Or how about this one I just saw: a piece looking at the so-called bromance between George Clooney and Adam Sandler. Thanksgiving with the bros, right?

Let's be honest. These days, anyone with a connected device and an agenda can cook up content and blast it onto the internet. It doesn't matter if it's true or not. This one crossed my feed just today: "Alex Bregman signs with the Seattle Mariners." But when you click through, it's just a local Seattle sports columnist wishing it into existence. In fact, at the end of the story it actually says, "This is a prediction, not a report."

In other words, it's kind of nonsense. But you know what? It still might come true.

It almost makes me nostalgic for the days when there were more actual newspapers and credible news organizations, and we all kind of cribbed from each other, to be honest. True story.

I worked at CNN during what many consider its heyday, the '80s and '90s. The network had bureaus all over the world and needed an enormous amount of content to fill 24 hours a day and serve affiliates. At the same time, CNN fought constant derision from the broadcast networks, who sneered that CNN stood for "Chicken Noodle Network." We ran a lean operation—no flash. Our mantra was "the news is the star." No highly paid blowhards.

That attitude also created a bit of an inferiority complex. The bosses looked at institutions like The New York Times and The Washington Post as the gold standard, and we were often tasked with matching or following their stories, whether or not they were suited for television.

So let's turn the way-back machine to 1986. I was working as a correspondent at CNN's Southeast Bureau in Atlanta, covering seven states. One day, a big boss reads a New York Times story about the Tennessee-Tombigbee Waterway, a major Army Corps of Engineers project designed to give ships access from the Gulf of Mexico to the Ohio and Tennessee River basins through Mobile, Alabama. It was also supposed to be a haven for water sports like fishing and water skiing.

The article alleged the Tenn-Tom was a failed pork-barrel project, largely unused and a total waste of taxpayer money. When the reporter visited, there wasn't a single water skier. Not one.

The boss barely finished the article before calling the bureau and ordering me to go to the Tenn-Tom and grill the Army Corps. He specifically demanded I ask one question: "Why are there no water skiers on the Tenn-Tom?"

The next day, my crew and I went to Columbus, Mississippi, met with Army Corps officials, boarded a boat, cruised the waterway, gathered B-roll, and conducted interviews.

Alienware's Flagship Area-51 Ryzen X3D Edition RTX 5090 Gaming PC Drops to \$4,450

Eric Song · IGN

If you're seeking chart-topping gaming performance, then Alienware's biggest and most powerful prebuilt desktop computer should be high on your list. For just a few more days the Alienware Area-51 AMD Ryzen 9800X3D Edition RTX 5090 gaming PC has dropped in price from \$5,650 all the way down to \$4,449.99, a savings of \$1,200. This is the best price I can find right now for an RTX 5090 prebuilt; other models and brands are currently selling for \$5,000 or more. This is better than buying an RTX 5090 graphics card by itself, which you won't be able to find for less than \$3,800.

Alienware Area-51 Ryzen Edition RTX 5090 Gaming PC

The Alienware Area-51 is Dell's flagship gaming PC. The product photos don't give it due justice; this is a big chassis that towers over the Aurora R16 model with superior build quality and a redesigned cooling system with even greater airflow. This is the only model that can be configured with the hot and power hungry GeForce RTX 5090 graphics card. The first wave of Area-51 systems featured Intel CPUs exclusively, with AMD X3D options only available since late November.

This \$4,450 config is equipped with an AMD Ryzen 7 9800X3D CPU, GeForce RTX 5090 graphics card, 32GB of DDR5-6400MHz RAM, and a 1TB SSD. Additional system details include a 360mm all-in-one liquid cooling system for the CPU and a massive 1,500W 80Plus Platinum power supply that allows plenty of headroom for future upgrades.

AMD Ryzen 7 9800X3D is the best gaming CPU for most people

...but you can also upgrade to the 9950X3D for a reasonable price

The AMD Ryzen 7 9800X3D is considered to be one of the best gaming processors on the market and outperforms any Intel or AMD non-X3D chip in games thanks to AMD's 3D-V-Cache technology. It only has eight cores, but that makes no difference in gaming since most games can't utilize more than eight cores (if that) anyways. That's why its gaming performance is nearly identical to the pricier 9900X3d and 9950X3D.

The RTX 5090 is the most powerful graphics card ever

The Nvidia GeForce RTX 5090 has emerged as the most powerful consumer GPU on the market. Although with this generation Nvidia has prioritized software updates, AI features, and DLSS 4 technology to improve gameplay performance, the 5090 still boasts an impressive 25%-30% uplift over the RTX 4090 in hardware-based raster performance. If you want the absolute best performance for your gaming PC, there is literally no other option from any other brand.

How to Follow IGN Deals Recommendations

The IGN Deals team has over 30 years of combined experience finding the best discounts and preorders available online. If you want the latest updates from our trusted team, here's how to follow our coverage:

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Eric Song is the IGN commerce manager in charge of finding the best gaming and tech deals every day. When Eric isn't hunting for deals for other people at work, he's hunting for deals for himself during his free time.

Privacy's Defender: Launch Party in Berkeley

Melissa Srago · EFF Deeplinks

We're celebrating the launch of Privacy's Defender, a new book by EFF Executive Director Cindy Cohn on Thursday, March 12—and we want you to join us! Cindy has tangled with the feds, fought for your data security, and argued before judges to protect our access to science and knowledge on the internet. In Privacy's Defender she asks: can we still have private conversations if we live our lives online?

Join the festivities for a live conversation between Cindy Cohn and Annalee Newitz followed by a book signing with Cindy.

REGISTER TODAY!

\$20 General Admission for 1 \$30 Discounted tickets for 2
\$12.50 Student Ticket All proceeds benefit EFF's mission.

Want your own copy of Privacy's Defender? Save \$10 when you preorder the book with your ticket purchase

WHEN: Thursday, March 12th, 2026 6:30 pm to 9:30 pm

WHERE: Ciel Creative Space Entrance located at: 940 Parker St, Berkeley, CA 94710

6:30 PM Doors Open 7:15 PM Program Begins

About the book

Throughout her career, Cindy Cohn has been driven by a fundamental question: Can we still have private conversations if we live our lives online? Privacy's Defender chronicles her thirty-year battle to protect our right to digital privacy and shows just how central this right is to all our other rights, including our ability to organize and make change in the world.

Shattering the hypermasculine myth that our digital reality was solely the work of a handful of charismatic tech founders, the author weaves her own personal story with the history of Crypto Wars, FBI gag orders, and the post-9/11 surveillance state. She describes how she became a seasoned leader in the early digital rights movement, as well as how this work serendipitously helped her discover her birth parents and find her life partner. Along the way, she also details the development of the Electronic Frontier Foundation, which she grew from a ragtag group of lawyers and hackers into one of the most powerful digital rights organizations in the world.

Part memoir and part legal history for the general reader, the book is a compelling testament to just how hard-won the privacy rights we now enjoy as tech users are, but also how crucial these rights are in our efforts to combat authoritarianism, grow democracy, and strengthen other human rights. Learn about the Privacy's Defender book tour.

Street parking is available around the building.

The main event space is wheelchair accessible, on concrete. Lively music will be playing, and the speakers will be using a microphone, so louder volumes are expected. EFF is committed to improving accessibility for our events. If you will be attending in-person and need accommodation, or have accessibility questions prior to the event, please contact events@eff.org.

Food and Drink

Wine & Beer will be available for purchase. Cellarmaker Brewing Co., located next door to Ciel Space, will be serving food until 8:00 pm.

Questions?

Email us at events@eff.org.

About the Speakers

Cindy Cohn Cindy Cohn is the Executive Director of the Electronic Frontier Foundation. From 2000-2015 she served as EFF's Legal Director as well as its General Counsel. Ms. Cohn first became involved with EFF in 1993, when EFF asked her to serve as the outside lead attorney in *Bernstein v. Dept. of Justice*, the successful First Amendment challenge to the U. S. export restrictions on cryptography.

Ms. Cohn has been named to TheNonProfitTimes 2020 Power & Influence TOP 50 list, honoring 2020's movers and shakers. In 2018, Forbes included Ms. Cohn as one of America's Top 50 Women in Tech. The National Law Journal named Ms. Cohn one of 100 most influential lawyers in America in 2013, noting: "[I]f Big Brother is watching, he better look out for Cindy Cohn." She was also named in 2006 for "rushing to the barricades wherever freedom and civil liberties are at stake online." In 2007 the National Law Journal named her one of the 50 most influential women lawyers in America. In 2010 the Intellectual Property Section of the State Bar of California awarded her its Intellectual Property Vanguard Award and in 2012 the Northern California Chapter of the Society of Professional Journalists awarded her the James Madison Freedom of Information Award.

Ms. Cohn is the author of the professional memoir, called Privacy's Defender to be published by MIT Press in March, 2026. She is also the co-host of EFF's award-winning podcast, How to Fix the Internet.

Annalee Newitz writes science fiction and nonfiction. They are the author of four novels: Automatic Noodle, The Terraformers, The Future of Another Timeline, and Autonomous, which won the Lambda Literary Award. As a science journalist, they are the author of Stories Are Weapons: Psychological Warfare and the American Mind, Four Lost Cities: A Secret History of the Urban Age and Scatter, Adapt and Remember: How Humans Will Survive a Mass Extinction, which was a finalist for the LA Times Book Prize in science. They are a writer for the New York Times and elsewhere, and have a monthly column in New

Super Mario Bros. (1993) Flashback Review

Scott Collura · IGN

I shouldn't be talking about the 1993 Super Mario Bros. movie right now. In fact, I'm kind of sorry for even bringing it up. It's 2026, Nintendo is firmly in a new era of cinematic adaptations of their popular video games, a second animated Super Mario Bros. movie is about to launch (which will almost certainly be a wildly successful product like the first), and a big-budget, live-action Zelda movie is in production as we speak. Dredging up an ancient Nintendo movie failure - one that is a thoroughly beaten Yoshi-shaped horse by now - feels both cruel and irresponsible, like being at your friend's wedding and telling everyone about the time he threw up in front of the entire class in middle school. Everyone should have moved on by now.

But sometimes it's important to think about where someone started so you can reflect on how far they've come, and video game movies have mostly improved since the live-action Super Mario Bros. movie was released to poor reviews, a very muted box office reception, and a lot of confused fans (with even more confused parents) over 30 years ago.

But hey, let's start with some positives. Despite so much of Super Mario Bros. being a baffling interpretation of the source material, Bob Hoskins and John Leguizamo's take on real-life Mario and Luigi going on an interdimensional road trip/rescue mission actually works. Their banter is frequently charismatic, endearing, and fun, even if it's mostly quips and catchphrases as hallucinatory nonsense unravels around them. They've got great chemistry and they're believable as two Italian American brothers bickering and bantering as they attempt to run a failing, family-owned Brooklyn plumbing business out of a van that barely works. (And that's even before they get pulled into an alternate universe and everything goes crazy.) If that setup sounds familiar, it's because it's essentially the same in the far more successful 2023 animated The Super Mario Bros. Movie - an interesting coincidence considering plumbing companies and broken-down utility vehicles aren't ever really explored in the video games.

It's a good thing that the dynamic between Mario and Luigi functions as well as it does since nearly everything around them increasingly seems to get more insane, bizarre, and distant from the source material. Super Mario Bros. plays out like someone quickly read the back of the box of a Super Mario game and cobbled together something that attempts to fill in the narrative blanks with total nonsense, wrapped in set pieces that mix the gritty New York street culture of the first live-action Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles movie with Blade Runner's dystopian future - none of which really makes any sense for Super Mario. Fantastical and psychotic things either happen as if they're totally normal and commonplace, or they're explained literally and in excruciating detail, a balance perfectly encapsulated by the film's opening minutes where a voiceover gives us the history of the dinosaurs, followed by a flashback to a group of nuns receiving an orphaned egg... that hatches into a human girl.

Why? No one knows, but it's possibly because one of the writers saw a picture of Daisy and another picture of Yoshi and decided they should be the same species.

It's a good thing that the dynamic between Mario and Luigi functions as well as it does since nearly everything around them increasingly seems to get more insane, bizarre, and distant from the source material.

This is technically a movie review, so I am now going to attempt to explain the plot. Deep breath: Two brothers living in Brooklyn meet a woman whose job it is to dig up dinosaur bones under the Brooklyn Bridge, because obviously that's where the most dinosaur bones are, and because the engineers who build bridges somehow didn't find them despite there being so many bones down there. And also they have no problem with people digging for dinosaur bones under functional bridges because that seems safe and fine for everyone involved. The woman gets kidnapped by two vaguely Italian guys from another dimension and the two slightly less vaguely Italian brothers fall through a magical illusory wall to find her, landing themselves in a manic lizard-themed version of Manhattan where everything is covered in wet webs. From there, a villain leader who orders fast food using a gun pointed at his television makes everyone's life slightly difficult because he wants the woman's necklace, and he also does evolution experiments on his employees, which they all seem OK with. The brothers then have to save the woman, defeat the villain, and learn several things about dinosaurs that aren't applicable to reality.

As the poster describes, this ain't no game. It is also frequently barely a movie, more a byproduct of the sheer disdain that movie executives frequently have for films aimed at children, treating the audience like passive lab rats who will just consume whatever is dumped into the feeding tubes. Kids deserved and continue to deserve better. That said, Super Mario Bros. is occasionally a fun time for a kids movie despite the fact that dozens and dozens of its moments are completely unrecognizable as a Super Mario Bros. movie. It's fast-paced, sometimes funny, and has likeable protagonists taking on a big, campy bad guy (played by none other than Dennis Hopper).

It's also got lots of stuff that kids thought was cool in the early '90s, like tyrannosaurs, big vehicles with unnecessary stuff glued on them like they're from an action-figure line, fireball guns, a zipline, and... prostitutes? More importantly though, it had the benefit of being one of the earliest live-action video game movies ever made, which means audiences didn't exactly have a strong point of reference for how these things should turn out (and also hadn't yet suffered through the somehow even worse Double Dragon movie which was released a year later). Watching the Super Mario Bros. movie is sort of like eating a knockoff version of your favorite breakfast cereal. Yes, it has marshmallows and fun oat shapes and a silly character on the packaging, but it all just tastes so fucking weird. These aren't General Mills Lucky Charms, they're First Street Magic Shapes where the laprechaun mascot is replaced with a clintart blue dinosaur

Discord Voluntarily Pushes Mandatory Age Verification Despite Recent Data Breach

Rindala Alajaji · EFF Deeplinks

Update February 25, 2026: Discord announced yesterday that it will delay the global rollout of its age verification system to the “second half of 2026”, instead of March. The company also said it has announced stricter requirements for partners offering facial age estimation, including that the process must be entirely on-device— Discord said one of its initial partners, Persona, “did not meet that bar.”

Discord has begun rolling out mandatory age verification and the internet is, understandably, freaking out .

At EFF, we’ve been raising the alarm about age verification mandates for years. In December, we launched our Age Verification Resource Hub to push back against laws and platform policies that require users to hand over sensitive personal information just to access basic online services. At the time, age gates were largely enforced in polities where it was mandated by law. Now they’re landing in platforms and jurisdictions where they’re not required .

Beginning in early March, users who are either (a) estimated by Discord to be under 18, or (b) Discord doesn’t have enough information on, may find themselves locked into a “teen-appropriate experience.” That means content filters, age gates, restrictions on direct messages and friend requests, and the inability to speak in “Stage channels,” which are the large-audience audio spaces that power many community events. Discord says most adults may be sorted automatically through a new “age inference” system that relies on account tenure, device and activity data, and broader platform patterns. Those whose age isn’t estimated due to lack of information or who are estimated to not be adults will be asked to scan their face or upload a government ID through a third-party vendor if they want to avoid the default teen account restrictions.

We’ve written extensively about why age verification mandates are a censorship and surveillance nightmare. Discord’s shift only reinforces those concerns. Here’s why:

The 2025 Breach and What’s Changed Since

Discord literally won our 2025 “We Still Told You So” Breachies Award . Last year, attackers accessed roughly 70,000 users’ government IDs, selfies, and other sensitive information after compromising Discord’s third-party customer support system.

To be clear: Discord is no longer using that system, which involved routing ID uploads through its general ticketing system for age verification. It now uses dedicated age verification vendors (k-ID globally and Persona for some users in the United Kingdom).

That’s an improvement. But it doesn’t eliminate the underlying potential for data breaches and other harms. Discord says that it will delete records of any user-uploaded government IDs, and that any facial scans will never leave users’

devices. But platforms are closed-source, audits are limited, and history shows that data (especially this ultra-valuable identity data) will leak—whether through hacks, misconfigurations, or retention mistakes. Users are being asked to simply trust that this time will be different.

Age Verification and Anonymous Speech

For decades, we’ve taught young people a simple rule: don’t share personal information with strangers online.

Age verification complicates that advice. Suddenly, some Discord users will now be asked to submit a government ID or facial scan to access certain features if their age-inference technology fails. Discord has said on its blog that it will not associate a user’s ID with their account (only using that information to confirm their age) and that identifying documents won’t be retained. We take those commitments seriously. However, users have little independent visibility into how those safeguards operate in practice or whether they are sufficient to prevent identification.

Even if Discord can technically separate IDs from accounts, many users are understandably skeptical, especially after the platform’s recent breach involving age-verification data . For people who rely on pseudonymity, being required to upload a face scan or government ID at all can feel like crossing a line.

Many people rely on anonymity to speak freely. LGBTQ+ youth, survivors of abuse, political dissidents, and countless others use aliases to explore identity, find support, and build community safely. When identity checks become a condition of participation, many users will simply opt out . The chilling effect isn’t only about whether an ID is permanently linked to an account; it’s about whether users trust the system enough to participate in the first place. When you’re worried that what you say can be traced back to your government ID, you speak differently—or not at all.

No one should have to choose between accessing online communities and protecting their privacy.

Age Verification Systems Are Not Ready for Prime Time

Discord says it is trying to address privacy concerns by using device-based facial age estimation and separating government IDs from user accounts, retaining only a user’s age rather than their identity documents. This is meant to reduce the risks associated with retaining and collecting this sensitive data. However, even when privacy safeguards are in place, we are faced with another problem: There is no current technology that is fully privacy-protective, universally accessible, and consistently accurate. Facial age estimation tools are notoriously unreliable, particularly for people of color, trans and nonbinary people, and people with disabilities. The internet has now proliferated with stories of people bypassing these facial age estimation tools. But when systems get it wrong, users may be forced into appeals processes or required to submit more documentation, such as government-issued IDs, which would exclude

The Foilies 2026

Dave Maass · EFF Deeplinks

Recognizing the Worst in Government Transparency

The Foilies were written by EFF's Beryl Lipton, Dave Maass and Aaron Mackey and MuckRock's Dillon Bergin, Kelly Kauffman and Anna Massoglia. Art by Shelby Criswell.

For the last six years, a class of journalism students at the University of Nevada, Reno, has kicked off each semester by filing their first Freedom of Information Act (FOIA) requests.

The assignment: Request copies of complaints sent to the Federal Communications Commission (FCC) about their favorite TV show, a local radio station, or a major broadcast event, such as the Grammys or the Super Bowl halftime show. The students are learning that the federal government and every state have laws establishing the public's right to request and receive public records. It's a bedrock principle of democracy: If a government belongs to the people, so do its documents.

In the past, the FCC always provided records within a few weeks, if not days. But that changed in September when students requested consumer complaints filed against NPR and PBS stations to see if there was absolutely anything at all to merit defunding public media. Seven months later — crickets.

Now the students are learning to persevere even when public officials demonstrate an utter disdain for transparency. And The Foilies are here for it.

Established in 2015, The Foilies are an annual project by the Electronic Frontier Foundation and MuckRock to recognize the agencies, officials and contractors that thwart the public's right to know. We give out these tongue-in-cheek "awards" during Sunshine Week (March 15-21), a collective effort by media and advocacy organizations to highlight the importance of open government.

This year, we've got a few "winners" whose behavior defies belief.

But it's not all negative. Those same Reno students are also assigned to file public records requests for restaurant health inspections. This semester, the records started to show up in their inboxes within 20 minutes.

If every agency followed Northern Nevada Public Health's example, we could sunset this Sunshine Week project.

Quick links:

The Love Letters Award - Gov. Greg Abbott

The Surcharge, Eh? Award - Vancouver, B. C.

The Shady Screenshot Award - Department of Homeland Security

The Discardment of Government Efficiency Award - DOGE

The Secret Eyes in the Sky Award - Chula Vista Police Department, Calif.

The City of Darkness Award - Richmond, Va.

The Flock You Awards - Multiple Winners

The Database Deletion Award - Muneeb and Sohaib Akhter, formerly of Opexus

The Love Letters Award - Gov. Greg Abbott

Last spring, the office of Texas Gov. Greg Abbott withheld communications between himself and one of the state's most powerful business figures, Elon Musk. The office claimed that the communications were exempt from public records law because they would reveal confidential legal and policy discussions, including how the state entices private companies to do business in Texas, or "intimate and embarrassing" information.

The claims were unelaborated boilerplate language based on exemptions in Texas' public records law. But if you're wondering what "intimate" and "embarrassing" exchanges Abbott and Elon Musk shared over email, you may be waiting a while.

Last fall, the Office of the Texas Attorney General ordered Texas Gov. Greg Abbott's office to release nearly 1,400 pages of communications between Abbott and Musk. About 1,200 of those pages were fully redacted — just sheets of gray obscuration. The records that were released don't reveal much more than an invitation to a happy hour or a reminder of the next SpaceX launch.

The Surcharge, Eh? Award - Vancouver, B. C.

Vancouver residents must now pay twice for public records. Despite taxes already funding the creation and storage of government records, the City Council approved charging people \$10 Canadian (about \$7.33 in the United States) every time they ask for "non-personal" public records.

Officials claim the fee is necessary to deter misuse and cover some administrative costs. The only people abusing anything, however, are the officials who imposed this tax on the public. The message Vancouver is sending is as crisp as a newly minted \$10 note: Secrecy is a higher priority than public accountability.

The Shady Screenshot Award - Department of Homeland Security

The Department of Homeland Security's banner year of lawlessness included backsliding on its transparency obligations.

Samsung's Premium 65" S90 4K OLED Smart TV Drops to Just \$1,099 for the Amazon Spring Sale

Eric Song · IGN

As part of its mega Spring Sale , Amazon recently dropped the price on one of Samsung's best OLED TVs. The highly rated 65" Samsung S90D 4K OLED Smart TV has just dropped in price to \$1,099 with free delivery. This is a new TV with a 1 year Samsung warranty. We recently named the Samsung S90 TV as our top pick for best gaming TV . The Amazon marketplace seller "Walt's TV" is an authorized Samsung reseller.

65" Samsung S90D 4K OLED TV for \$1,099

The Samsung S90D is the prior generation 2024 model. A new "S90F" model is available for about \$250 more, but the differences are minor. The S90D is equipped with Samsung's proprietary quantum dot (QD) OLED panel. QD OLED panels are brighter than traditional OLED panels without losing the color accuracy, range, and wide-viewing angles that OLEDs are known for. Compared to a traditional LED LCD TV, an OLED TV offers superior image quality, near-infinite blacks, near-infinite contrast ratio, and near-instantaneous response times.

OLED technology aside, the Samsung S90D also has all the features you'd want in a gaming TV . It has a native 120Hz panel that can be pushed to as high as 144Hz as well as four total HDMI 2.1 ports for running 4K at 120Hz on a PS5 or Xbox Series X gaming console. The S90D also supports variable refresh rate and auto low latency mode. This is an es-

pecially good complement to the recently released Playstation 5 Pro console since it can drive more games in quality mode (native 4K @ 120fps) than the standard PS5, which often needs to be set to performance mode (upscaled 4K).

Is this a good TV for the Nintendo Switch 2?

Despite being a current generation console, the Nintendo Switch 2 has lax TV requirements compared to the PS5 or Xbox Series X. When the Switch is connected to its dock and a television, it is only capable of outputting a 4K resolution signal at up to 60 frames per second. It can go up to 120fps if the resolution drops to 1080p, but the data rate required for both these options is pretty much the same. Oddly, it doesn't even get VRR when docked – that's reserved for handheld mode only. The Switch 2 console, however, will still benefit greatly from the Samsung's gorgeous OLED panel.

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QOTD: Which Designer Should Head To Jaguar Land Rover?

Tim Healey · The Truth About Cars

Jaguar Land Rover needs a new design boss after the departure of Gerry McGovern.

So, who should get the job?

Should a "name" designer like Ralph Gilles depart Stellantis and head to JLR? Is there some young up-and-coming rock star, perhaps one who most of us haven't heard of, that's ready for the next step?

Who can step in and lead the design team at a struggling company?

You know the drill, you know what to do. Go ahead and sound off below.

[Image:]

Become a TTAC insider. Get the latest news, features, TTAC takes, and everything else that gets to the truth about cars first by subscribing to our newsletter .

The S90D also supports variable refresh rate and auto low latency mode.

Eric Song

☺ Trust Us With Your Face | EFFector 38.4

Christian Romero · EFF Deeplinks

Do you remember the last time you were carded at a bar or restaurant? It was probably such a quick and normal experience, that you barely remember it. But have you ever been carded to use the internet? Being required to present your ID to access content online is becoming a growing reality for many. We're explaining the dangers of age verification laws, and the latest in the fight for privacy and free speech online, with our EFFector newsletter .

For over 35 years, EFFector has been your guide to understanding the intersection of technology, civil liberties, and the law. This issue covers Discord's controversial rollout of mandatory age verification , a leaked Meta memo on face-scanning smart glasses , and a Super Bowl surveillance ad that said the quiet part out loud.

Prefer to listen in? In our audio companion, EFF Associate Director of State Affairs Rin Alajaji explains how online age verification hurts free expression for all users. Find the conversation on YouTube or the Internet Archive .

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EFFECTOR 38.4 - ☺ Trust Us With Your Face

ANALYSIS

IN BRIEF

Car and Driver, Car and Driver: We compare the Charger's Hurricane twin-turbo six with the old-school Hemi V-8 and let the test results do the talking.

Nico DeMattia, Jalopnik: Bosch managed to create a timeless design when it introduced spark plugs to the masses. But it would have never come to pass if not for another invention.

BBC Sport, BBC Sport: Before Carlos Alcaraz became the youngest man to complete the career Grand Slam, he was simply Carlitos from Murcia. This is his story.

Scientific American, Scientific American: During their 10-day mission, this four-person crew will swing around the far side of the moon —and potentially travel farther from Earth than anyone in history

BBC Sport, BBC Sport: Wales boss Craig Bellamy discusses everything from football to Balkan history - and playing Ken and Barbie - in an exclusive, in-depth interview with BBC Sport.

BBC Sport, BBC Sport: No-one knew what to expect at football's first official penalty shootout - and no-one wanted to go down in history as the first to miss.

Scientific American, Scientific American: The COVID pandemic ushered mRNA vaccines into the spotlight, and the technology has even greater potential. Here's what to know about the way that they work, their safety, and more

Car and Driver, Car and Driver: They'll join a new plug-in-hybrid model and a body-on-frame pickup, which are both scheduled to arrive in the next three years.

Car and Driver, Car and Driver: It looks like more colorful cars are poised for a comeback, displacing the grayscale ones that currently saturate parking lots.

Shane Schmid, Jalopnik: Vortec engines have lasted for over three decades. There are reasons as to why they lasted so long, but there are also reasons as to why they fell out of favor.

Alvin Reyes, Jalopnik: Bridgestone used to be a top contender in the world of tires, but can its modern incarnation stand up to Michelin? Consumer Reports has the answer.

Bigphoto, One Big Photo: Did you know that approximately 41% — or around four of 10 — of the 50 million or so rental housing units in the U. S. are owned by individual investor landlords? Owning real estate can be a great investment. You'll benefit as the property appreciates in value over time, and you can [...]

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